

Forgiveness and Repair

סְלִיחָה

selichah · seh-lee-CHAH · forgiveness

“But with you there is forgiveness, so that we can, with reverence, serve you.”

Psalm 130:4, NIV

Read Psalm 130:3-4 together. The prayer imagines the weight of a record of wrongdoing, then turns toward forgiveness and a renewed relationship with God.

Look closely at the Hebrew

Selichah is a noun: forgiveness. In the verse, ha-selichah includes ha-, the definite article. Salach is the related verb: to forgive. Keep the grammar distinct from the interpretation: the word does not itself mean forgetting, erasing, or rebuilding trust.

1. What has changed in Judah?

Judah once proposed selling Joseph. Years later, he offers to become a slave so that Benjamin can go home. Compare the two choices. Rabbi Jonathan Sacks reads Judah’s reversal through Maimonides’ account of repentance: faced with the chance to repeat a wrong, a changed person acts differently.

Genesis 37:26-27; 44:33; Maimonides, Repentance 2:1

2. Why is repayment not enough?

Maimonides says that someone who has wronged another must restore what is owed and seek that person’s forgiveness. Even after repaying money, there is a person to approach. Repair has a practical part and a personal part.

Maimonides, Repentance 2:9

Read and discuss

1. What makes Judah’s later choice more persuasive than an apology alone? What would changed behavior look like in an ordinary disagreement?
2. Why might someone still need an apology after a debt is repaid? Name one thing an apology can acknowledge that money cannot.

For reflection: What can I put right before I ask to be forgiven?

Further reading

Rabbi Jonathan Sacks: [The Birth of Forgiveness](#)

A reading of Joseph, Judah, and the possibility of becoming a different person.